

Elephant Path (Hathi Paer / Hathi Pul)

ہاتھی پیڑ

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Attributed to Shah Jahan
- Built in: c. 1631-32
- Cost: Not documented in available sources
- Built for: Allowing royal elephants carrying members of the household to ascend from ground level to the palace terrace

2. Construction Details

- Design: Extremely wide treads and shallow risers, engineered specifically for elephant traffic rather than human foot traffic
- Form: The stairs form a three-sided courtyard; the fourth (south) wall was later demolished to create a modern access path
- Original access: The only original entrance to this courtyard was the Hathi Pol gateway at its southwest corner, whose exterior is integrated into the Picture Wall

3. Historical Background

- Located at the northwest corner of the fort, just south of the Shah Burj Quadrangle - a purpose-built piece of transport infrastructure rather than a decorative structure.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- This is a rare surviving example anywhere in South Asian palace architecture of a stairway engineered specifically for elephant traffic - most historic stairs, even grand ones, were built for human feet.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Most palace staircases are built to impress a visitor walking up them. This one was built to carry an elephant - wide, shallow, unhurried steps designed so that a member of the royal household, seated in a howdah high above the ground, could be carried smoothly from the outside world straight up into the private palace terrace.